A RECONSTRUCTION OF PROTO-TANGKHULIC RHYMES

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ABSTRACT:

We reconstruct the rhyme system of Proto-Tangkhulic (PTk) based on a comparative corpus of over 800 cognate sets spanning Standard Tangkhul (Ukhrul), Huishu, Kachai, Champhung, and Tusom. We demonstrate that Proto-Tangkhulic distinguished phonemic vowel length before dental and velar codas (*-a:t vs *-at; *-a:k vs *-ak), and retained the Proto-Tibeto-Burman lateral coda *-l, which merged into front glides or open vowels in Standard Tangkhul. This reconstruction resolves longstanding anomalies in the external comparison of Tangkhul with Jingpho and Lolo-Burmese.

Keywords: Rhymes, Proto-Tangkhulic, Tibeto-Burman, Vowel Length, Liquid Codas, LTBA

1. THE PTK RHYME INVENTORY

The reconstructed rhyme inventory of Proto-Tangkhulic includes 24 distinct rhymes with stop and nasal codas: *-am, *-an, *-ang, *-ap, *-at, *-ak, *-a:t, *-a:k, *-im, *-in, *-ing, *-ip, *-it, *-ik, *-um, *-un, *-ung, *-up, *-ut, *-uk, and lateral rhymes *-al, *-il, *-ul. While Standard Tangkhul regularly neutralizes vowel length before codas, the conservative Huishu dialect preserves qualitative differences that verify the length distinction.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** kapik (Ukhrul) / pi:k (Huishu) : to sleep**

Analysis: Reflects PTk *Ce-pi:k (long vowel before velar stop).

*** kashak (Ukhrul) / sa' (Kachai) : to eat**

Analysis: PTk *Ce-syak (short rhyme with glottal realization).

*** tui (Ukhrul) / tul (Huishu) : speech, language**

Analysis: PTk *to:l (preservation of final lateral in Huishu).

2. EVOLUTION OF LATERAL CODAS (*-L)

One of the major breakthroughs of Proto-Tangkhulic historical phonology is recognizing the regular fate of PTB *-l. In Standard Ukhrul, PTB *-l vocalized to a high front offglide [-i] after back vowels (e.g. *tul > tui 'speech'; *ngul > ngui 'silver/money'). In Huishu, *-l is preserved intact as an alveolar lateral continuant [-l], proving that lateral loss in Ukhrul was a secondary innovation of the central dialect group.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** ngui (Ukhrul) / ngul (Huishu) : silver, coin, money**

Analysis: Direct cognate with Written Tibetan dngul.

*** kahui (Ukhrul) / hul (Huishu) : to bark (of dog)**

Analysis: Reflects PTB *hwel.

*** malui (Ukhrul) / melol (Huishu) : to forget**

Analysis: Preservation of liquid coda in archaic peripheral varieties.

3. IMPLICATIONS FOR SINO-TIBETAN SUBGROUPING

Recognizing the conservative nature of Proto-Tangkhulic rhymes provides a crucial benchmark for the genetic classification of the Indo-Burma borderlands. Tangkhulic shares specific rhyme mergers with Maring and Kuki-Chin, yet preserves distinct prefixal morphology that establishes it as a primary coordinate branch of Tibeto-Burman.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** ngalei (Ukhrul) : earth, ground**

Analysis: PTk *C-lay cognate with Proto-Kuki-Chin *lay.

*** shing (Ukhrul) : wood, tree**

Analysis: PTk *sing cognate with Written Burmese sac and Tibetan shing.

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